

Is Piracy Good?

And we're not talking about the end-user; we mean for software vendors

Agent 001

We've seen quite about enough news on software pirates being tried. If it's not a 10-year-old kid being sued by the RIAA (Recording Industry Association of America), it's lawsuits against the developers of P2P networks and Web sites.

Although I buy all my software, or just use freeware, I don't think you can completely stop people from pirating software—considering that many software products cost more than the average PC today! There will always be two types of software programmers: the creators and the crackers! There will also always be two types of end-users: the haves and the have-nots, or more appropriately, the will-nots. Rather than get into the undecidable ethical debate about “to crack or not to crack,” let's stick to software piracy and the effects it has on the industry.

It's Easy, It's Fun, It's Illegal!

Most of us in India have a lot of pirated software on our computers, and part of the reason is that we *really* cannot afford to pay for even software that's cheap by American standards—\$10 is Rs 450! Obtaining working software has become the

simplest thing on earth—just go to a download site such as www.download.com, download the software, and then hit Google or Yahoo! Search, looking for a crack.

You'll almost always find what you're looking for (you know what I mean...) in a flash; download the crack, and you instantly become one of the millions of software “pirates” across the globe. A lot of us don't even know it's wrong!

Take for example of the e-mails I get every day: at least two of them per day are from readers asking me to provide them with a serial key or download link to a “patch” for some well-known software or the other! When I politely reply to these people informing them that this is against the law, and if they really like the software that much—if it is that useful to them—then perhaps they should consider buying it, here's a taste of what I get as responses...

“... my system assembler can give it to me for free, but he is out of town so I asked you...”

“It's illegal? But my friend has it... it came with his computer; and his computer itself costs less than that software... if he didn't pay why should I?”

“Do you seriously expect me to believe that you do not pirate yourself?”

“Never mind, I found the key myself... thanks for nothing!”

You're Breaking The Law

It's important to realise that by downloading a crack for a software, or using someone else's licence key to unlock a software, is illegal. Laws across the globe vary, but generally, the punishment could be a hefty fine and/or jail time.

Oh Shush, You Little **** Activist! Piracy is Good

That is what was said to me when I recently chided a female friend who called me to ask for a “free” version of a very popular (and expensive) image editing software! The verbal abuse did not ruffle me—I'm used to that—but her statement, “Piracy is good,” left me speechless.

A lot of muttering and stammering and hurled abuses later, things calmed down a bit and I got down to asking her how exactly piracy was good, and for whom.

“Not unless you buy me coffee and get me that software,” she teased. Long story short, I took her out for coffee, but made sure she got someone else to do her piracy work.

Here's what transpired:

Me: So how can piracy be good? Good for you, yes, but not good